

Crack the code

6 Name the Indian mathematician who first described binary

Indian Cos retain better

Indian companies are very good at retaining employees for long periods of time, according to a new study. Employees in the IT sector can expect hefty increments this year

Feature

and IT managers use a framework approach to select applications.

We, at Sterlite, have been using Open Source applications quite extensively for the past three years. At present, our file servers, Internet acceleration servers, security firewalls, mail servers, document management systems, project management systems, storage servers, and desktop-level backup applications run on open source. Here, we are not talking of a single location, but multiple, large manufacturing locations on multiple servers.

And, we are not running them because they are free. That's a misconception that many people have. The TCO might be less but it's certainly not free. The kind of uptime and performance that we get is, if not better, definitely as good as provided by the commercial applications.

When you run a search, for any single requirement, one will come up with many applications. Logically, as the next step we test them out in a development environment and check out the different features and their technical fitment with the existing architecture. And then in the end, we subject the application to the 'enterprise litmus test for open source.' This is the clincher that

helps us take the final "go" or "no-go" decision, particularly because unlike commercial applications one doesn't have a support agreement to seek help from the vendor. So it makes sense to check that the application ecosystem is sound before you commit your enterprise to it.

- **Development activity:** As part of this criterion, one needs to check how frequently updates have been coming and what the open bugs or feature requests are. Very frequent updates or very few updates are both problematic. Frequent updates point to an unstable system that requires frequent tweaking whereas delayed updates point to a dead or dying development cycle. The sweet spot, from our experience, is around two to three updates every year.

- **Development roadmap:** Try to find out the roadmap as envisaged by the developers. There should be a plan for at least 18 months ahead. Lack of a clearly defined roadmap normally points to an impulsive application lifecycle. For some applications which are not very critical and are small this can do. But generally when you are planning to deploy an application in an enterprise, there has to be a clear enough roadmap.

- **Forum activity:** This is one place where you can get lot of information about the application. First, check the activity on the forum. There has to be a sizable number of members and daily updates with people asking questions and getting answers. Second, check that answers should be provided by more than one person. It should not be that only one person is providing the answers to all the questions raised by members. Third, look at the kind of questions being raised by members. Is there any pattern? Is there any feature that everyone's asking for? Or is there some feature that is not working for lots of people? You can go ahead and ask questions yourself and see what kind of responses you get.

- **Developer background:** You need to check the background under which the application development got started. How many people are involved? Are they from a common place or whether the organisations are spread out? It's better if they are spread out.

- **Availability of commercial support:** First, you have to check if there are organisations which provide paid support. How is it structured? Is it incident-based? Can it be done remotely? It's better if there is a mechanism for commercial support.

And while all this information can be conveniently sourced from the developers' site, do not forget to share it with the entire eco-system of your organisation. We have developed this framework based on our experience and have shared it with other organisations as well. Empirical evidence from them also supports the framework.

By using the above mentioned criteria, IT personnel can take informed decision regarding the fitment of the particular application to an enterprise's requirements. If it does not have a good fit, one can still use the application, but in that case there will be an impact on TCO. This is because one needs to either take external help or the IT department will have to devote additional time to the issues arising from the use of the application. **d**

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